

List of endangered buildings

An architectural equivalent of the endangered species list should be drawn up for all the special, irreplaceable bits and pieces of our environment that suddenly seem to be on the verge of extinction.

Movie palaces are one example. Among the most spectacular buildings ever built, true extravaganzas of kitsch, the great film palaces of the twenties and thirties with their gilded plaster ceilings, their velvet and rococo furnishings, are being torn down left and right for parking lots.

Or churches. The Cheswick Institute, in a recent study, called urgent attention to the danger of many Boston churches, especially those in the Back Bay, whose thinning congregations can no longer meet expenses as land values, taxes and maintenance costs rise.

Mills are another example. So are wharves. Most urgent of all, railroad stations.

Unless something is done, and soon, we're not going to have enough railroad stations left to remind ourselves of what they looked like. If that happens, we'll have lost an invaluable link to our past.

A report just published, written for Educational Facilities Laboratories by New York architects, Hardy Holzman, Pfeiffer Associates, documents the extent of the threat.

Just the bare numbers are a shock. Of 40,000 stations built in this country since 1830, only half remain. Many of these are derelict, orphaned by a railroad industry that now gains only four percent of its revenue from passenger service.

So who cares? Some obviously don't. Comments one railroad official: "I venture to say that the communities involved are glad to see eyesores go."

But these buildings weren't considered eyesores when they were

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built. Indeed, at the height of station building around the turn of the century, the new railroad station downtown was likely to be the pride and focus of the entire community.

That pride was often justified. Partly because of the absence of previous examples—the Greeks and Romans, after all, didn't have railroads — station architects were forced into an unusual degree of inventiveness. They created an amazing variety of styles, adapting freely from castles, chalets, renaissance palazzos, classical temples, almost anything. The result is at once one of the richest and surely the quirkiest vein of native American design.

Not all the news is bad. In Lincoln, Neb., an abandoned whistle-stop station has been turned into a drive-in bank. Roll-top desks, lounge chairs and other memorabilia collected from other stations have been pressed into service for the new bank. As they should, the old building and the new use are allowed to comment ironically on each other.

In Fargo, N.D., a station is now home for 10 firms of decorators and artists; in Oberlin, O., another houses a Head Start program; in Chattanooga, a company calling itself Chattanooga Choo Choo has restored a magnificently pompous station as a complex of restaurants and shops. In the largest and best known example, the immense Union Station in Washington is scheduled to open in time for the Bicentennial as a national visitor center.

Nearer home, Concord, Mass., has converted its station to odd shops and a pricey restaurant. With its wood beams disappearing into

acoustic tile ceilings, this conversion doesn't exactly sing in key with the old station but the exterior retains some charm. The Allston Depot, too, is now a restaurant.

All these examples, the best and the worst, have one important thing in common: the buildings have been put to work, not insulted by being put on display as museums.

Probably the phoniest thing you can do to any genuine link with the past is turn it into theater, which is what a museum does. When, instead, a building is recycled, put back to work with an appropriate live new use, its past doesn't disappear but rather underlies the present like the drum beat under the symphony. The effect is far richer.

Methods for funding these conversions, still inadequate are as varied as the buildings and include Federal grants, revenue sharing, foundations, etc. Some cities have purchased buildings as a stopgap, then resold them to development groups. Special zoning incentives and development rights transfers constitute another vehicle. But for the largest stations, the most threatened of all, such as New York's Grand Central, some new ideas are likely to be needed, and soon.

Until recently, our throwaway society threw away buildings as easily and mindlessly as we burned energy. We weren't only wasting a valuable resource—our inventory of built space—but, perhaps even more important, we were destroying one means of satisfying our human need to orient ourselves in the timescape.

If those attitudes are changing now, as they seem to be, we may regain something of ourselves as well as save some nice buildings.